

ANI

These include the BrahMos missile with ranges between 450 and 800 kilometres, the Kh-35 ALCM with a range of 260 km, and the Israeli-developed Crystal Maze 2, a precision air-to-surface ballistic missile with a strike range exceeding 250 km, effective even in GPS-denied environments and capable of targeting high-value assets such as long-range radars and air defence systems. The IAF also fields the Spice 2000 glide bomb, fitted with an add-on kit for 450/900 kg warheads. It has high accuracy and a range of approximately 60 km.

The Pakistan Air Force (PAF), on the other hand, operates 387 fighters, among them the JF-17, J-10 CE and F-16, besides 57 attack helicopters, and relies on LY-80 SAMs and PL15 missiles with Chinese collaboration and artificial intelligence-driven electronic warfare capabilities. Pakistan, in fact, holds numerical superiority over India in Airborne Warning and Control System (AWACS) and Airborne Early Warning and Control (AEW&C) aircraft, critical for air surveillance and battle management, with nine platforms compared to India's five. The PAF operates 5-6 Saab 2000 Erieye AEW&Cs, with a new unit (serial 23-058) inducted in 2024, featuring a 450 km detection range, an AESA (Active Electronically Scanned Array) radar with 150°-300° coverage, and real-time tracking of aircraft, missiles and ground targets. India, by contrast, operates three IL-76-based Phalcon AWACS with 400 km range and 360° EL/W-2090 radar, and two Embraer ERJ-145 Netra Mk-1 AEW&Cs with 240° indigenous AESA radar and 200-250 km range, apart from the 12 P8i used for multi-domain surveillance across land, air and sea. "Numerically," says Air Vice Marshal Manmohan Bahadur (retd), "we are strongly placed and have superior technology, but we have to look out for latest technologies which Pakistan may have got from China." According to him, while both nations have 4.5 Generation fighters (India has the Rafale and Pakistan the J10C), how you utilise them tactically is what will matter.

India's navy, with 294 vessels, includes two aircraft carriers (INS *Vikramaditya* and *Vikrant*), 20 submarines (including three nuclear-powered) and 75 naval aircraft, for global power projection. Pakistan's 114-ship navy, equipped with eight submarines and nine frigates, focuses on coastal defence and is supported by Chinese-supplied Type 054A/P frigates. In a conventional war, where India's naval superiority and precision air-launched missiles clash with Pakistan's nimble drone fleet and AWACS advantage, the India-Pakistan military balance has reached a precarious equilibrium. Turkish corvettes fortify Pakistan's shores, while India's aircraft carriers command the Indian Ocean, encapsulating a high-stakes rivalry defined by cutting-edge technology and geopolitical manoeuvring in 2025.

THOUGH IT IS ALIGNED WITH INDIA, THE UNITED STATES IS URGING BOTH COUNTRIES TO DE-ESCALATE AS IT DOES NOT WANT INSTABILITY IN SOUTH ASIA

The Russia-Ukraine conflict first validated drone warfare, and it is playing a significant role in the current stand-off between India and Pakistan. India has strong unmanned platforms like the Israeli-made Heron, Searcher and Harop UAVs, besides the American-made MQ94 Reaper for cross-border surveillance, suppression of enemy air defence and precision strikes. It has also strengthened its anti-drone capabilities with a mix of indigenous and imported electronic warfare systems for both soft-kill (jamming) and hard-kill (laser, kinetic or net-based). These include the Krasukha from Russia and the SMASH 2000 Plus systems from Israel. Pakistan, meanwhile, has looked to China and